

Exams can be stressful for many children and young people. Some stress is normal and can help motivation, but too much can affect wellbeing, learning and confidence.

Your support makes a real difference.

Common responses to stress:

- Excessive worry about results or "failing"
- Struggling to sleep or complaints of headaches/stomach aches
- Seeming irritable, tearful, withdrawn, or more sensitive
- Avoiding revision or becoming a perfectionist.



How parents can help:

Keep things manageable

- Help your child break revision into short, realistic sessions
- Encourage focus on key topics, not everything

Praise effort, not just results

- Support healthy routines
- Prioritise sleep over late-night cramming
- Encourage regular meals and water
- Gentle activity (a walk, stretching) can reduce stress

Provide emotional reassurance

- Listen without immediately trying to fix things
- Acknowledge feelings: "I can see this feels really hard"
- Remind them that exams do not define their worth or future

Reduce pressure at home

- Avoid comparisons with siblings or peers
- Keep language calm and neutral
- Balance revision with breaks and normal family life
- Slow breathing: breathe in for 4, out for 6 (1–2 minutes)
- “Brain dump”: write worries down before revision or bedtime
- Rephrase negative thoughts: “I’m doing my best with what I know”

On exam days

- Keep mornings calm and predictable
- Encourage starting with questions they know
- Remind them they don’t need 100% to do well

When to seek extra support

Consider additional help if stress is:

- Affecting sleep most nights
- Causing frequent distress or physical symptoms
- Leading to avoidance of school, college, or exams

You can speak to:

- School/college staff (tutor, head of year, exams officer)
- GP or school mental health support services

Key takeaways

- **Exams measure performance on one day - not intelligence, character, or potential.**
- **Your reassurance, calm presence, and belief in your child matter far more than any grade.**

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a Spurgeons
webinar on
exam stress.**

